

Silence and Implication Lab Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 20-30 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	silence-and-implication-lab

Big idea: Meaning often depends on implication; silence can communicate without explicitly claiming.

Overview

Students analyze how what is left unsaid can communicate assumptions, politeness, doubt, or power.

Student Prompt

Inspect Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Dialogue: 'Did you like my presentation?' 'Well, your slides were very colorful.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Dialogue: 'Are you coming to the meeting?' 'I have a lot of homework tonight.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Silence and Implication Lab Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Dialogue: 'Are you coming to the meeting?' 'I have a lot of homework tonight.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Meaning often depends on implication; silence can communicate without explicitly claiming.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	Can silence be evidence?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how meaning often depends on implication; silence can communicate without explicitly claiming.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Use brief dialogues with simple social contexts.
- Remind students that implication depends on shared norms and can be misread.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Dialogue: 'Did you like my presentation?' 'Well, your slides were very colorful.'
- Dialogue: 'Are you coming to the meeting?' 'I have a lot of homework tonight.'

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Give pairs a short dialogue with one ambiguous silence or indirect reply.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Students list what was explicitly said and what was implied.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Groups add context cards that change the implication.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Students decide which interpretation is most justified.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
5	Debrief how implication functions in everyday and institutional knowledge.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- What was said, what was implied, and what did you add?
- Which context clues justify your reading?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may say language merely expresses thought rather than shaping interpretation.
- Students may identify bias in extreme examples but miss subtle framing.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Explains how wording changes interpretation before evidence is judged.
- Uses concrete language choices as evidence for a TOK claim.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Support: provide two possible implications.
- Challenge: distinguish implication from assumption and inference.

Extension Tasks

- Students rewrite an indirect statement as a direct claim and compare effects.
- Connect implication to diplomacy, advertising, poetry, or classroom feedback.

Related Activities

- Ambiguity Court
- Euphemism and Moral Distance
- Loaded Headline Laboratory